The Hierarchy of the Beast System: Institutional Power, Elite Coordination, and Economic Dependency Across Political Regimes

A Comparative Political-Economy Framework with a Theological Interpretation

Mateo Largo (Independent Researcher)

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Abstract

This paper develops the **Hierarchy of the Beast System** (HBS) as a proposed analytical vocabulary for describing recurrent configurations of concentrated institutional power. Its motivating image is a five-position order: resource-controlling elites; political and legal administrators; knowledge-producing and health-related institutions; coercive organizations; and the working population. We argue that the order can be investigated in capitalist, state-socialist, and hybrid economies without presupposing a single secret director, equivalence among institutions, or a universal verdict about particular professions. The term *Beast System* is treated as a theological metaphor inspired by Revelation 13 and 17–18, not as an empirically established supernatural or conspiratorial entity. A multiplex network model separates resource control, rule-making, legitimation, coercion, and material reproduction and makes the critical distinction between hierarchy, interdependence, and capture. We derive conditional propositions about power concentration, institutional closure, information independence, coercive capacity, and citizens' exit and voice. We then outline historical comparative illustrations, falsifiable hypotheses, a coding scheme, and an identification strategy using governance indicators, institutional records, and policy-level evidence. The central conclusion is deliberately conditional: analogous mechanisms of concentration can arise under different ideologies, but the distribution of power, safeguards, and ordinary public benefits differ substantially. The framework becomes useful only when its claims are measurable, its rival explanations are considered, and legitimate public services are not conflated with domination.

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1 Introduction: the problem of institutional hierarchy

Modern citizens encounter authority through institutions that rarely present themselves as one integrated structure. Wages and credit come from employers and financial intermediaries; laws come from legislatures, courts, and agencies; expert accounts of reality emerge from universities, professional associations, newsrooms, and scientific organizations; coercive sanctions are applied by police, courts, and military establishments; and many citizens make their living within markets or bureaucracies whose terms they do not control. These activities are often beneficial and necessary. They can also, under particular arrangements, produce forms of dependency that magnify the practical power of a comparatively small coalition. This paper asks how these two truths can be studied together.

The phrase *Hierarchy of the Beast System* names a provocative intuition: institutional power may

be organized such that those controlling resources are able to affect rules, those authorized to interpret rules can shape accepted knowledge, security organizations can enforce compliance, and ordinary people must reproduce the order through their work, payments, and everyday participation. Here the term *beast* is neither a classification of persons as evil nor a claim that a single identifiable cabal secretly operates society. It is a metaphor for an institutional configuration in which political and economic survival appears conditional on submission to concentrated authority. Its biblical source suggests a possible moral question; the empirical question remains separate.

The core hypothesis is **functional recurrence without ideological identity**. A liberal market economy, a centralized one-party socialist economy, and a mixed political economy might display recognizable *functions* of hierarchy even though legal ownership, party organization, expressive liberty, electoral contestation, and opportunities for exit differ dramatically. Conversely, no system should be assigned an HBS classification merely because it contains wealthy people, bureaucrats, academics, police, or taxes. Every developed polity contains differentiated occupations, and differentiation itself does not establish capture, oppression, or illegitimate rule.

This manuscript contributes four things. First, it replaces a morally charged ladder of persons with a set of analytically distinct institutional **functions**. Second, it identifies mechanisms by which functional layers can reinforce each other, including rents, agenda-setting, expert dependence, sanctioning, and resource reproduction. Third, it specifies conditions under which the mechanisms break down: electoral contestability, independent judicial review, plural ownership, professional independence, organized labor, investigative journalism, decentralized civil society, and effective exit or voice. Fourth, it offers observables, falsification criteria, and a research design suitable for comparative evaluation.

The argument stands in a tradition of elite theory, political sociology, and institutional economics rather than replacing it. Michels's account of oligarchical tendencies within organizations [Michels, 1915] emphasizes organizational asymmetry; Dahl's examination of competing centers of influence [Dahl, 1961] represents an important pluralist response; Stigler's account of the demand for economic regulation [Stigler, 1971] and later work on state capture [Hellman et al., 2000] explain particular pathways from resources to public authority. The HBS proposal is therefore best regarded as an integrative heuristic and a research agenda, not a discovery of a previously unknown law.

Three distinctions govern the entire paper. **Power** is a capacity to shape another actor's options; **domination** is a condition of relatively unconstrained, potentially arbitrary power over those options; **coordination** is cooperation among institutions and is not necessarily wrongful. Strong sanitation programs, functioning public hospitals, or stable security institutions may be manifestations of administrative competence, not evidence of a malign hierarchy. In political economy the normative conclusion depends on authorization, transparency, proportionality, recourse, distributional consequences, and actual agency, not the mere presence of the institution.

A further caution concerns scale. National institutions are not single minds. Legislatures have factions; firms compete; professional associations dispute standards; courts reverse agencies; bureaucratic offices resist political principals; and popular groups create institutions of their own. A simple vertical image is useful for introducing functions, but a faithful explanation requires a network of competing, cooperating, and sometimes antagonistic organizations. The tension between a simple hierarchy and a complex network becomes a central design feature of the formal model rather than a contradiction to be hidden.

2 Conceptual foundations and the relevant literature

2.1 Elite theory and its critics

Classical elite theory asks why political organizations tend to concentrate decision rights among a relatively small leadership group. Michels famously argued that coordination requires delegation, expertise, and control of internal information, generating tendencies toward oligarchy even in democratic parties and associations [Michels, 1915]. Such a tendency is neither a universal empirical law nor evidence of a transnational command center. A professional union, cooperative, public agency, or political party can accumulate leadership power because members face substantial costs of monitoring and replacement. The mechanism is organizational, not dependent on a particular economic ideology.

Dahl offers an essential corrective: political power can be dispersed among multiple overlapping groups, with different coalitions prevailing on different issues [Dahl, 1961, 1971]. Political equality may be imperfect without there being one decisive apex. This literature provides a rigorous test of the HBS intuition: if the same actors reliably dominate independent institutional domains, the integrated-hierarchy claim gains plausibility; if the domains possess independent and competitive centers, the integrated claim weakens. Any serious analysis must search for both patterns rather than treating power concentration as certain in advance.

The study of agenda-setting further complicates simple elite arguments. Influence can consist not only of obtaining desired decisions but also of excluding issues from consideration [Bachrach and Baratz, 1962] or shaping the terms in which preferences are understood [Lukes, 2005]. Such effects are harder to observe than executive appointments or budget transfers. The analyst must avoid circular inference: a policy's absence cannot by itself establish that someone suppressed it. Evidence must include rules of access, gatekeeping procedures, documented communications, exclusion patterns, and defensible alternatives.

2.2 Institutional economics and rents

Stigler's economic theory of regulation identifies circumstances under which organized groups seek favorable public rules [Stigler, 1971]. Olson shows why concentrated interests may organize more readily than dispersed populations [Olson, 1965]. These claims do not entail that all regulation is captured; legitimate market failures and collective goods can justify intervention. They do identify an empirical asymmetry: an advantage worth millions to a small group may induce more sustained pressure than a modest per-person cost imposed on millions.

Acemoglu and Robinson link distributions of political power to institutional choice and the stability of democracy [Acemoglu and Robinson, 2006]. Acemoglu's model of inefficient institutions specifies extraction, factor-price manipulation, and political consolidation as mechanisms by which politically powerful groups may favor arrangements that reduce overall efficiency [Acemoglu, 2006]. Hellman and colleagues document the concept of *state capture* in transition economies, where influential firms shape the rules of the game themselves rather than merely evading existing rules [Hellman et al., 2000]. In an HBS analysis, capture is a possible edge from resource holders to rule makers, not an assumed property of every market system.

North, Wallis, and Weingast distinguish limited-access orders, which stabilize elite arrangements partly through restricted entry and rents, from open-access orders that enable broad competition and institutionalized checks [North et al., 2009a,b]. This is a closer analogue to the present proposal than the claim that all governments are fundamentally interchangeable. Whether access is closed, whether organizations can form independently, and whether violence is subject to public rules alter the structure's real-world operation. An institutional order can be stable through inclusion as well as

through exclusion.

2.3 Bureaucracy, coercion, and competing powers

Weberian analysis treats administration as a durable form of rational-legal authority with both capabilities and risks [Weber, 1978]. Mann distinguishes despotic power from the infrastructural capacity needed to implement collective decisions throughout a territory [Mann, 1984]. A state able to vaccinate children, adjudicate contracts, deliver emergency assistance, and maintain roads has administrative reach, but such reach is not synonymous with arbitrary repression. This distinction is especially important in interpreting the healthcare and enforcement levels of the original hierarchy.

Modern studies of autocratic rule attend to elite bargaining and the costs of repression as well as to mass compliance. Svolik identifies problems of authoritarian power-sharing and control [Svolik, 2012]; Gerschewski organizes stabilizing strategies around legitimation, repression, and co-optation [Gerschewski, 2013]. These frameworks offer mechanisms resembling the HBS intuition while disallowing the shortcut that every institution is automatically loyal to one leader. Elite fragmentation and bureaucratic infighting can threaten the very concentration that the vertical metaphor emphasizes.

Foucault's work investigates discipline, surveillance, and forms of authority operating through institutions and bodies [Foucault, 1977, 1978]. It highlights diffuse social regulation rather than only commands issued from a sovereign apex. Scott likewise cautions that simplified administrative categories can produce harmful outcomes even when intentions are reformist [Scott, 1998]. Both are useful for analyzing expert authority and administrative classification, but neither licenses an inference that scientific expertise is inherently fraudulent or healthcare is merely an instrument of control.

2.4 Power without monopolistic control

The strongest rival account is not that unequal power never exists, but that it is imperfectly coordinated and often checked. Hirschman's categories of *exit*, *voice*, and *loyalty* describe ways people respond to declining organizational performance [Hirschman, 1970]. Ostrom's work shows how communities can govern shared resources without collapsing their choices into a simple market-versus-state binary [Ostrom, 1990]. Deliberative public spheres [Habermas, 1989], independent associations, and contentious movements further create channels of resistance. A theory of hierarchy that cannot explain effective institutional opposition, independent expertise, and successful citizen challenge is incomplete.

3 Theological vocabulary: what the metaphor can and cannot claim

The title deliberately invokes the New Testament's Book of Revelation, especially chapters 13 and 17–18, where images of beasts, kings, merchants, worship, and constraints on buying and selling connect imperial power with economic and religious allegiance. Revelation is an apocalyptic text, rich in symbolic representation, written for early Christian audiences navigating pressure, identity, hope, and imperial social realities. Major commentators emphasize its literary conventions, first-century setting, and continuing interpretive disputes [Collins, 1984, Bauckham, 1993, Koester, 2014]. The present paper does not claim to resolve those theological disputes.

In one influential reading, the beast is related to Roman imperial sovereignty and the demand that political authority receive quasi-religious allegiance. Another approach treats the imagery typologically, as a recurring warning about governments or institutions that claim ultimate loyalty. Futurist readings, by contrast, may connect the text to an anticipated future political-economic order. These interpretations are not interchangeable. The paper employs a **typological and critical** reading, in which a biblical image prompts examination of modern institutional dependencies. It makes no

assertion that a particular present-day government, profession, vaccine, payment system, party, or named person has been identified by Revelation.

Revelation 13:16–17 is particularly resonant because economic exchange is described as conditioned on a sign of allegiance. Yet the inference from the existence of taxes, licensing, banking rules, or occupational credentials to that passage is invalid without an additional theory of coercive allegiance. Most routine administration includes obligations; the relevant question is when obligations are arbitrary, discriminatory, unreviewable, or tied to compelled ideological conformity. Revelation 18's account of commerce and luxury similarly poses moral questions about wealth and exploitation without proving that all commerce is corrupt.

The theological framework provides a **normative warning**, not a statistical measurement. It asks whether human institutions begin to demand the unconditional loyalty that religious belief may reserve for God. An empirical project asks different questions: Who controls appointments? What is the causal effect of major donors or party committees on policy? Can expert conclusions be challenged? What remedies exist after a wrongful sanction? How much control do workers have over exit, bargaining, and representation? Conflating these registers would weaken both biblical interpretation and social science.

Christian traditions themselves do not offer one uniform political model. Biblical texts include admonitions to political authorities, commands of conscience, criticisms of exploitation, and arguments for civic order. The analytic use of the beast image must therefore permit government that protects the vulnerable, medical institutions that save lives, and expertise that genuinely corrects error. The expression *beast system* should be reserved for a proposed pattern of coercive and unaccountable coordination, not used as a blanket epithet for people who serve the public.

Finally, the word *slavery* requires discipline. In political rhetoric it sometimes denotes severe economic dependency or restricted agency. In legal and historical research, slavery denotes forms of ownership or coercion far more specific and extreme than ordinary wage labor or taxation. Throughout this paper, the working population is described as the **material-reproduction and dependency layer**. The comparison with bondage, where used at all, is explicitly metaphorical. This prevents the concept from erasing the histories of enslaved persons or the distinctions among market employment, compelled labor, serfdom, imprisonment, and literal chattel slavery.

4 A five-function model of institutional power

The HBS heuristic retains five positions but treats them as functions that can be held by different organizations, and sometimes by the same organization. Institutional roles are not moral judgments about individual officeholders. They also do not form a perfect ranking: a police institution may directly control a business; a court may constrain a billionaire; a professional association may defy a ministry; a workers' movement may change a government. What matters is the effective allocation of resources, decision rights, legitimating authority, sanctions, and the capacity to reproduce an order.

4.1 Function 1: command over scarce resources

The resource function, denoted R, encompasses control over capital, land, credit, investment, essential infrastructure, major public budgets, or strategic means of production. Its occupants could be influential private owners in a market economy, senior party-state officials directing allocation in a centrally planned system, or a mixed group in hybrid arrangements. Resource concentration becomes domination only when it also creates durable and poorly contestable authority over other people. Ownership by itself, large enterprise scale, and the administration of public goods are not sufficient

evidence.

Institutional power is shaped by the *conversion rate* between economic advantage and political access. The researcher should trace campaign contributions, revolving-door employment, procurement, party appointment, preferential lending, monopolistic licenses, and the assignment of strategic inputs. Resource elites may conflict with one another or lack political leverage; such disconfirming cases are analytically valuable. In an explicitly state-socialist order, economic command may be subordinated to party authority rather than residing above it. Thus the first function is often not a distinct social stratum.

4.2 Function 2: rule production and administration

The rule function, L, consists of legislation, regulation, adjudication, taxation, licensing, and administrative implementation. It includes politicians, lawyers, judges, regulators, and career officials but distinguishes the authority exercised by different bodies. Lawyers frequently defend dissidents against the state, courts may veto executive actions, and administrators may enforce statutes with little independent discretion. Treating every legal professional as part of a uniform ruling coalition obscures precisely the variation that a defensible theory needs to explain.

The crucial indicator is not whether a legal order has coercive rules but whether it selectively distributes discretion, burden, and redress. Relevant measurements include unequal access to courts, exemptions available only to connected firms, insulation of agencies from oversight, legal predictability, and whether unpopular citizens can challenge official decisions. Legal institutions are both possible transmission channels of power and possible barriers to its concentration.

4.3 Function 3: epistemic and cultural mediation

The knowledge function, K, comprises education, science, accreditation, media, professional expertise, public information, and organizations that establish widely accepted categories of truth and risk. Healthcare and food systems belong here only in the limited sense that they use and communicate specialized knowledge, set technical standards, and mediate access to essential goods. Their productive, logistical, and clinical functions are distinct from public persuasion. A hospital is not analytically reducible to a propaganda organization, and a professor is not analytically reducible to an agent of political command.

Two opposite mechanisms are plausible. Independent expertise can increase accountability by exposing environmental hazards, government failures, corruption, and ineffective treatment. Captured expertise can instead make favored interests seem inevitable or conceal contrary evidence. The discriminating questions concern data access, replicability, conflict-of-interest disclosure, scientific dissent, publication freedom, peer review, funding concentration, medical outcomes, and correction mechanisms. An HBS research program must compare claims against independently observed outcomes rather than assuming that disagreement with an institution proves institutional capture.

4.4 Function 4: coercion and enforcement

The enforcement function, E, includes police, military institutions, prisons, intelligence services, and other organizations authorized to impose sanctions. The state may claim legitimate authority to use force under law, but legitimacy depends in part on constitutional arrangements, proportionality, procedural justice, democratic authorization, and civilian oversight. The presence of public security is not evidence of systematic repression. In fact, police who protect assembly rights and courts that sanction abusive officers can limit domination by other powerful actors.

The coercion function is therefore measured by *discretionary and asymmetric deployment*, not by spending alone. Indicators might include politically selective arrest, military intervention in domestic governance, restrictions on peaceful opposition, unreviewable surveillance, impunity, or unequal access to legal remedies. The hypothesis is strongest when sanctions target challenges to entrenched interests and when oversight channels cannot meaningfully reverse decisions.

4.5 Function 5: work, compliance, and social reproduction

The reproduction function, W, consists of households, workers, taxpayers, small businesses, consumers, caregivers, and other people whose material activity sustains institutions. Workers are not merely passive subjects. Their labor may be indispensable, their voting and collective bargaining may redistribute power, and their refusal to participate may reshape rules. A useful model distinguishes *dependence* from *powerlessness* and allows exit, voice, collective action, and mutual aid.

Economic dependency can be high even under legally voluntary exchange, particularly when income is insecure, essential services are nonportable, or switching institutions is costly. But taxation is not automatically extraction for a ruling minority: public revenue can finance health, education, safety, and transfers that improve popular welfare. To classify a fiscal flow as extractive requires a beneficiary-incidence analysis and credible evidence about representation, service provision, and opportunity costs.

4.6 The hierarchy diagram is a first approximation

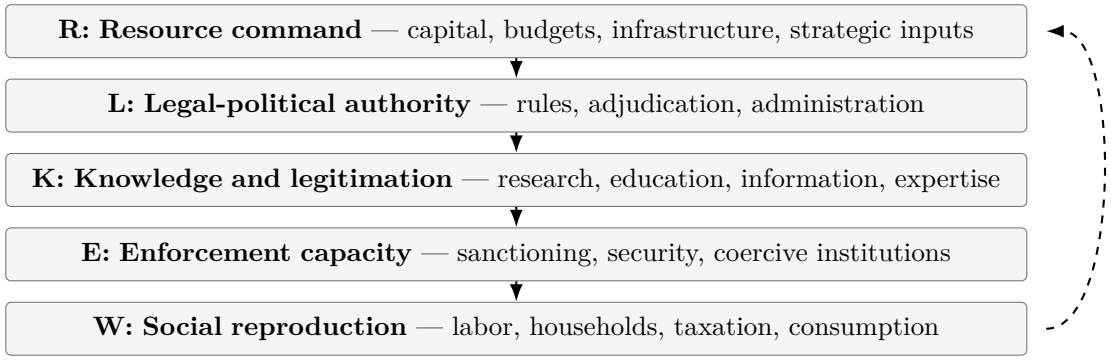


Figure 1: The five-function heuristic. Solid arrows depict the proposed top-down channels; the dashed arrow illustrates feedback from social reproduction. Arrows express possible causal pathways, not universal domination or an empirically measured relationship.

The diagram is deliberately schematic. In observed settings, the knowledge function can influence legislation directly, coercive bodies can capture resource allocation, and citizens can overthrow incumbents. The next section consequently replaces the single chain with a multiplex network in which every edge is conditional and potentially reversed.

5 A formal political-economy model

5.1 Institutional actors, edges, and capabilities

Let a polity at time t be represented by a directed multiplex network $G_t = (V_t, \mathcal{E}_t)$, where V_t denotes organizations or organizationally coherent actor groups, and $\mathcal{E}_t$ contains five types of weighted links. The links are A^r (resource transfers and dependencies), A^l (rule-making authority), A^k (epistemic

influence and communication), A^e (coercion and sanctions), and A^w (labor, finance, and material reproduction). The weight $a^m_{ij,t} \in [0,1]$ characterizes a documented capacity of actor i to constrain a feasible action of actor j through mechanism m. The scale is conceptual unless a measurement scheme has been fixed in advance. It should not be interpreted as a number that can be discovered from impressions alone.

An organization can occupy multiple functions: a party-state committee may allocate investment, issue binding directives, oversee media appointments, and direct security institutions. A large corporation may finance expertise and lobby regulators while depending on courts to enforce contracts. A local citizens' association may operate a clinic and influence legislation. The matrix representation therefore avoids the unwarranted assumption that social classes and institutional functions coincide one-to-one. A proposed mapping $F : V \to 2^{\{R,L,K,E,W\}}$ allows many-to-many role membership.

For empirical implementation, each layer would require separate indicators. Resource links might be measured using contracting flows, ownership networks, and discretionary subsidies; political links through legal appointment and veto powers; knowledge links through financial sponsorship and editorial governance; enforcement links through command structures and observed sanctions; reproduction links through taxation, wage dependence, essential-service access, and mobility constraints. Direct causation remains a further question. An appointment gives an actor potential influence; evidence that the appointment altered a decision is needed to infer realized influence.

We define a **capture link** as an influence relationship that meets three conditions: (i) it grants an actor privileged access or discretion, (ii) the privilege weakens otherwise applicable public accountability or contestability, and (iii) material evidence links this asymmetry to an institutional output. A donor's permitted disclosure-compliant meeting is not automatically capture. A suspiciously favorable regulation is not proof by itself; process records, counterfactual comparators, and competing explanations matter. This conservative definition reduces the risk of turning policy disagreement into an accusation of institutional conspiracy.

5.2 Concentration, closure, and reversibility

Let $s^m_{i,t}$ be actor i's share of decision-relevant control within domain m after normalization, with $\sum_i s^m_{i,t} = 1$. A familiar concentration measure is

$$H_{m,t} = \sum_{i \in V_t} (s^m_{i,t})^2.$$

Higher $H_{m,t}$ implies more concentrated measured capacity within the domain. However, concentration is neither a complete description of power nor a normative verdict. Emergency coordination may rationally centralize command; independently reviewed scientific consensus may be concentrated because of strong evidence; a fragmented security apparatus may generate its own dangers. We therefore supplement H_m with a **contestability index** $Q_m \in [0,1]$ measuring transparency, appeal rights, institutional independence, effective competition, and credible replacement of decision makers.

A first-pass **unaccountable concentration** quantity is

$$U_t = \sum_{m \in \{r,l,k,e,w\}} \omega_m H_{m,t}(1 - Q_{m,t}), \qquad \sum_m \omega_m = 1, \quad \omega_m \geq 0.$$

This is an illustrative index, not a validated measurement instrument. It forces a conceptual separation between strong institutions and unaccountable institutions: two states can have similarly centralized public health systems but very different conditions for challenging mistakes. Any empirical

use must preregister weights and run sensitivity analysis, rather than tune weights until preferred countries receive high scores.

A further dimension is **cross-domain integration**. Define $C_{mn,t}$ as the extent to which the same coalition commands appointments, budgets, sanctions, or agenda control across institutional domains m and n. A high concentration score with low cross-domain integration describes dispersed oligopolies rather than a single effective hierarchy. We therefore write a hypothetical integration statistic

$$I_t = \frac{2}{M(M-1)} \sum_{m<n} C_{mn,t}, \qquad M = 5,$$

with $C_{mn,t} \in [0, 1]$ established from explicit overlap and cross-domain authority measures. A strong HBS claim requires evidence of both unaccountable concentration and integration. The stricter criterion prevents a false inference from the separate existence of financial elites, professors, police, and officials to the existence of one master organization.

5.3 Endogenous reproduction and the feedback problem

Institutions persist by drawing resources, securing compliance, and reproducing legitimacy; citizens can also reorganize or withdraw cooperation. Let the state vector be $x_t = (R_t, L_t, K_t, E_t, W_t)$ with each element representing the aggregate capacity exercised by the respective functions. A schematic dynamic relation is

$$x_{t+1} = B_t x_t + D_t z_t + \varepsilon_t,$$

where B_t collects inter-institutional dependencies, z_t represents external shocks, and ε_t comprises unobserved influences. The stability of the system cannot be inferred merely because B_t contains positive links: institutions can exhibit negative feedback, substitution, saturation, and legitimacy losses. If local linearization were warranted, dominant eigenvalues might provide a mathematical language for persistence, but observational estimation of B_t remains demanding.

The sociological significance is straightforward. A resource concentration can alter legal rules, but laws can also break up monopolies. Expert communication can legitimize policy, but it can also disclose abuses. Enforcement can deter dissent, but unlawful enforcement can mobilize widespread opposition. Workers can reproduce an unequal arrangement through compliance and consumption, but they can also form unions, cooperatives, social movements, and electoral coalitions. The same arrow is never guaranteed to have the same sign in all periods.

We can model a representative governing coalition's expected utility as

$$\max_{p,c,g} \Pi(p, c, g) = B(p) + \rho(c) - \kappa(g) - \phi(\text{opposition}, \text{oversight}),$$

where p is a policy vector, c is the degree of political coalition control, g represents coercive measures, B is a material or organizational benefit, ρ captures rents from control, κ is the direct and reputational cost of coercion, and ϕ reflects accountability costs. The model does not assume that governments maximize private rent; the coalition's objective may include public welfare, ideology, national security, or survival. A specific theory must supply these preferences and test them rather than using the equation as a disguised assertion about motives.

5.4 Conditional propositions and counterexamples

Proposition 1 (integration is not implied by differentiation). The observation of differentiated resource, legal, epistemic, enforcement, and labor functions does not establish a common hierarchy. Evidence of cross-functional command, privileged coordination, or joint suppression of contestation is required. The proposition follows directly from the possibility of independent and adversarial nodes in G_t.

Proposition 2 (checks can interrupt transmission). Holding resource concentration constant, effective independent review and opportunities for voice should reduce the probability that attempts at policy capture generate persistent unreviewable outcomes. This is a conditional comparative-static expectation, not a universal causal law; its empirical validity depends on whether measured checks actually bind powerful actors.

Proposition 3 (control paths differ by regime). In privately owned economies with competitive elections, one important path may run from concentrated economic resources to public lobbying and policy influence. In party-state command economies, another path may run from central appointment authority to allocation and enforcement. Both can yield dependency, but the direction of control and the available remedies may differ. The proposition rejects the simplistic claim that capitalist and communist societies have identical apexes.

Proposition 4 (public benefit is compatible with hierarchy). Strong coordinated capacities can produce high public welfare, especially when organized around transparent mandates and effective error correction. Hence a correlation between administrative centralization and high service delivery would not falsify the existence of hierarchy as such, but would challenge the equation of hierarchy with exploitation. To be informative, the HBS theory must predict *when centralization becomes arbitrary domination*, not simply where coordination exists.

Counterexamples to an unqualified HBS thesis include independent courts invalidating policies backed by major donors, military leaders refusing unlawful orders, professional bodies publishing findings unwelcome to funders, citizens electing governments that redistribute advantages away from incumbents, and worker organizations obtaining bargaining gains without elite permission. Such observations are not anomalies to explain away; they are necessary evidence for distinguishing accountable pluralism from integrated capture.

6 The same functions under different economic and political orders

6.1 Market-capitalist democracies

A market-capitalist democracy generally separates many private ownership rights from formal political offices. Owners and investors may influence public policy through lobbying, campaign activity, economic bargaining, advertising, think tanks, and employment networks; policymakers may influence private actors through taxation, procurement, competition law, and licensing. The resulting system is neither a simple top-down chain nor an ideally equal contest. Stigler and Olson identify incentives for concentrated interests to organize around policy [Stigler, 1971, Olson, 1965], while pluralist theory predicts opposition among groups and issue-specific alliances [Dahl, 1961].

A frequently cited study by Gilens and Page evaluated 1,779 U.S. policy issues and reported substantial independent associations between policy outcomes and the preferences of economic elites and business-oriented groups [Gilens and Page, 2014]. The interpretation of those results remains disputed, particularly where the preferences of income groups are correlated and where measurement and model specification constrain conclusions. It would be an error to translate one study into proof

that ordinary voters have no influence or that every policy is engineered by wealthy masters. The study is better used as a reason to specify issue-level hypotheses and seek replication with alternative designs.

The legal and information layers also contain institutional counterweights in this setting: competitive firms can challenge restrictions; journalists investigate business-government transactions; courts may protect speech and property rights against officials; and universities can conduct independent research. Whether these channels are effective is an empirical matter. The HBS model therefore predicts variation *within* capitalist democracies as well as variation between such democracies and centralized authoritarian systems.

To operationalize the American example, one could select industries with high policy stakes, code lobbying expenditures and hearing access, record the origin of technical policy language, examine relationships between regulated firms and agencies, and test whether policy changes systematically advantage participants after controlling for changes in public preferences, economic conditions, and demonstrable service benefits. The object would be narrow identification of specific capture processes, not a verdict about an entire nation or political party.

6.2 One-party state-socialist systems

In systems historically organized around dominant communist parties, political appointment mechanisms have often played an especially central role in controlling economic management, public communication, and security organizations. The resource function is frequently embedded inside party or state authority rather than sitting above it as a distinct class of private financiers. In Kornai's treatment of socialism, state-enterprise relationships and soft budget constraints create distinctive patterns of bargaining and economic performance [Kornai, 1986, 1992].

Yet party-state control must not be idealized as perfectly unified. Research on Soviet leadership careers found segmentation and conflicts within the ruling elite and difficulty imposing complete control over the industrial bureaucracy [Lane and Ross, 1995]. An account of communist societies that assumes one omnipotent elite is therefore as vulnerable as a capitalist account that assumes every firm follows one coordinated financial interest. Bureaucratic competition, informational bottlenecks, informal exchange, local negotiation, and resistance all matter.

Compared with a competitive democracy, a closed one-party system may impose greater constraints on independent party formation, media competition, and electoral replacement. However, comparisons require specified country-periods, not ideological labels alone. The USSR of the late 1980s, China during particular reform episodes, and other state-socialist systems differed in property rules, enterprise autonomy, repression, international exposure, and reform pathways. A credible study would estimate those differences rather than pooling them into a single timeless type.

The proposed HBS translation is therefore a **role permutation**. In the privately financed capture story, a resource-rich actor may seek privileged influence over a nominally distinct legal institution. In a party-state configuration, the political leadership may appoint resource allocators and secure privileged access internally. Both pathways can suppress scrutiny or impose costs on workers, yet they vary in ownership structure, channel of influence, accountability mechanisms, and capacity for change. Functional resemblance does not erase institutional diversity.

6.3 Mixed, social-democratic, and hybrid systems

Most observed economies combine markets, public administration, welfare institutions, and regulation. Social democracy, developmental-state strategies, federal arrangements, and hybrid regimes distribute functions differently. Strong public healthcare does not necessarily reflect greater political domination:

universal access may reduce dependence on a particular employer, thereby improving economic exit options. Similarly, public financing of education can broaden knowledge access, although the design of academic governance and professional freedom determines whether public financing compromises intellectual independence.

Hybrid arrangements may combine powerful political parties with competitive business sectors, electoral institutions with weakened accountability, or concentrated private holdings with centralized state patronage. Such combinations provide useful variation for HBS tests because they challenge the false dichotomy between a supposedly pure capitalism and pure communism. The explanatory variables are actual ownership, appointment, oversight, contestation, and sanction structures. Labels are relevant historically and ideologically but weak proxies for those mechanisms.

6.4 What remains invariant—and what does not

Across political-economic systems, it is plausible that institutional survival depends on resource allocation, binding rules, claims to legitimacy, the ability to enforce decisions, and material work. That is the **functional invariant**. It does not follow that all societies share a single social pyramid, identical coercive practices, or equal degrees of freedom. Open organizational entry, independent courts, rights of association, transparency, and civic pluralism can fundamentally alter the same nominal functions. These differences are the central object of explanation, not inconvenient exceptions.

A model of institutional domination must also distinguish harmful capture from ordinary democratic influence. Labor unions, disability advocates, public-health researchers, consumer organizations, and business associations all may seek law reform. Interest representation becomes problematic when access is arbitrary, concealed, or unaccountably exclusive, not when citizens or organizations make claims. Otherwise the theory would condemn the very popular participation that might protect the working population from concentrated power.

7 Five mechanisms of reproduction and their failure modes

7.1 Mechanism A: resource dependence and selective rents

Unequal command over scarce resources can translate into political leverage when policymakers depend on investment, employment, media reach, or privileged expertise. Concentrated beneficiaries also have stronger incentives to monitor specific regulations than diffuse taxpayers or consumers [Olson, 1965]. Public procurement and subsidies can create rents in either privately owned or publicly commanded economies. The crucial questions are who receives benefits, whether eligibility is contestable, and whether competitors and citizens can audit decisions.

The mechanism fails or weakens when organizational entry is open, procurement is transparent, conflicts of interest are disclosed, and decisions face judicial and legislative scrutiny. Competitive procurement, disclosure requirements, antitrust law, and effective appeals can reduce capture even while the state remains economically powerful. A counterargument also deserves attention: stable relations between officials and industry can sometimes transmit useful information and coordinate large infrastructure projects. The analyst must distinguish productive coordination from exclusive privilege using outcome evidence and procedural safeguards.

7.2 Mechanism B: lawmaking, administrative discretion, and legitimacy

Legal authority converts policy preferences into binding obligations. Different constitutional systems allow differing degrees of executive discretion, legal challenge, local autonomy, and legislative oversight.

Administrative complexity can make rules hard for ordinary citizens to understand, while specialized organizations develop internal legal and compliance teams. This asymmetry may favor wealthy or well-connected actors. Yet legal predictability, judicial independence, and due process can also convert arbitrary command into rules binding on rulers themselves.

The HBS question is not whether a government taxes but whether legal requirements are selectively waived or aggressively applied to favor an entrenched coalition. Research needs to differentiate the distributive effects of taxation from its coercive collection. Taxes financing redistributive public goods may lower citizen vulnerability; taxes financing private rents may increase it. The direction cannot be read from the revenue total alone. Nor does a high number of regulations imply illegitimate domination when rules demonstrably improve safety or competition.

7.3 Mechanism C: narratives, knowledge, and professional authority

Institutional actors compete to establish publicly credible descriptions of reality. Funding may shape the questions researchers ask; editors may select topics; professional licensing can determine who may provide specialized services; and bureaucratic data classifications can affect what policymakers perceive. The power to define a problem often precedes the power to choose its solution [Bachrach and Baratz, 1962, Lukes, 2005, Scott, 1998]. An empirical study should investigate the traceable production of an authoritative claim, including source transparency, peer criticism, data access, and whether dissenting evidence receives due consideration.

The words *healthcare*, *drugs*, and *food* often provoke concerns about dependence because these goods are essential to life. That dependence creates potential conflicts of interest among insurers, manufacturers, public agencies, clinicians, distributors, and households. It does not establish that medicine is primarily a control technique, that scientific findings are politically fabricated, or that food systems share one coordinated agenda. Any such claim requires product-specific, policy-specific evidence. The most reliable methods examine regulatory records, independent replication, real-world health outcomes, published conflicts, reimbursement incentives, and competing institutional judgments.

The same institutions can act as checks. Independent epidemiology can reveal industrial contamination; investigative reporters can expose governmental misconduct; judicially protected academic freedom can challenge a party line; and medical professionals can resist unsafe orders. A serious HBS account specifies conditions under which expertise is captured *and* conditions under which expertise supplies an effective defense against capture. Treating knowledge professionals as inherently subordinate to masters eliminates the model's ability to account for such cases.

7.4 Mechanism D: sanctions and credible threats

Coercion matters because disagreement has different consequences when authorities can seize assets, detain people, impose fines, or deploy organized force. A regime with unreviewable surveillance and politically selective punishment may suppress opportunities to expose capture. Modern authoritarianism research distinguishes coercion from elite bargaining and legitimation, indicating that coercion is one element in a broader stability strategy [Svolik, 2012, Gerschewski, 2013]. Threats may sometimes produce compliance without frequent observable arrests, complicating measurement.

Yet security authority is also central to protecting individuals against private violence, extortion, and attacks on public institutions. The morally relevant distinction is not the existence of police or armed forces but the legality, necessity, proportionality, selectivity, and independent accountability of their conduct. The model predicts a stronger concentration risk when sanctioning institutions are institutionally dependent on the same actors whose decisions they are supposed to review. That prediction can be tested using appointment rules, disciplinary records, complaints systems, and

differential enforcement outcomes.

7.5 Mechanism E: work, material flows, and learned compliance

Households reproduce political-economic arrangements through taxes, labor, care, consumption, and the socialization of new members. Institutional dependence rises when people lack savings, alternative employers, geographic mobility, legal assistance, union representation, or credible political voice. Behavioral adaptation can stabilize rules even when people privately disagree with them. Nevertheless, economic participation is not merely a sign of submission. Workers supply essential public goods and hold potential bargaining, electoral, professional, and moral power.

The research challenge is to distinguish voluntary coordination from constraints imposed through monopoly, discrimination, or violence. Wage dependence in an economy with many competing employers differs from dependence on a single compulsory employer; a portable public health benefit may increase exit freedom compared with employment-tied coverage; mandatory taxation with meaningful electoral consent and clear public benefit differs from confiscatory appropriation without review. The model must therefore include mobility, bargaining coverage, income protection, access to courts, and procedural recourse alongside aggregate tax or wage measures.

The five mechanisms also produce feedback effects. Persistent rents can finance better advocacy; favorable rules can increase those rents; protected narratives can discourage scrutiny; coercive capacity can deter competition; and material dependence can raise the cost of dissent. Conversely, investigative reporting can expose rents, court judgments can reverse rules, professional standards can constrain officials, enforcement agencies can refuse unlawful commands, and citizen coalitions can reorganize resource allocation. The central empirical task is to estimate which feedback loops dominate under particular institutional conditions.

8 Comparative illustrations: three distinct pathways

This section uses historically informed *illustrations* rather than original case-study estimates. It neither establishes an HBS classification for entire societies nor asserts uniform coordination by everyone in a broad occupational category. Its purpose is to show how the theory would organize evidence and identify contrary evidence. Full historical adjudication would require archival work, cross-checked datasets, and local expertise.

8.1 United States: organized interests and institutional contestation

In the United States, the most plausible elite-concentration pathway begins with unequal private financial resources and organized advocacy, proceeds through political access and the specialized development of policy, and potentially affects the distribution of legal benefits and burdens. Regulatory capture is one such mechanism. The process has been investigated in economics, political science, and policy analysis for decades [Stigler, 1971, Gilens and Page, 2014]. OECD work underscores that lobbying is not inherently illegitimate: actors may provide essential information while also generating risks of opaque, unequal access and improper influence [Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, 2021].

An appropriately narrow project might examine a set of procurement decisions or environmental exemptions across two decades. Researchers would identify all applicants, the dates and content of regulatory proposals, agency meetings, disclosed donations, staff movements, judicial challenges, and public-health or economic outcomes. Statistical models could then test whether connected applicants receive systematically different treatment after accounting for technical merit and relevant legal

constraints. No claim about conspiratorial intent would be needed: a pattern of preferential decisions associated with institutional access would already be analytically significant.

Countervailing evidence would include competitive tendering in which politically unconnected firms consistently win on merit, investigative disclosures that produce sanctions against favored firms, judicial decisions that invalidate preferential rules, and elections that measurably alter policy. These observations would imply that resource influence is real but contestable. The strongest conclusion might then be that specific institutional interfaces are vulnerable to capture, not that the nation has a single hidden master.

The healthcare example makes this nuance concrete. Pharmaceutical manufacturers, insurers, professional groups, patients, clinicians, employers, and public agencies have competing interests. Patents, reimbursement schedules, evidentiary standards, and public funding can create significant stakes. Yet life-saving treatments, scientific error correction, and independent clinical judgment can also emerge within the same system. An HBS study would test a defined conflict—for instance, whether one reimbursement change privileged a small group without an evidence-based justification—rather than infer that healthcare as a whole is a technology of domination.

8.2 Soviet party-state: political appointments and bureaucratic bargaining

The Soviet example reverses the standard private-capital-first causal story. Under its historical party-state arrangements, appointment hierarchies and central decisions about production were central to resource allocation. Analysts of the socialist economic system have emphasized persistent bargaining among enterprises and administrative bodies, soft budget constraints, and information problems [Kornai, 1986, 1992]. The primary HBS link would be from political appointment and control to economic resources and informational structures, rather than from independent major shareholders to elected legislators.

The original five-level hierarchy would misdescribe this situation if it put private money interests permanently above politicians. Political command and resource control were intertwined, while informal exchange and fragmented administrative authority complicated central decisions. Research on the leadership of the Soviet Communist Party in 1981–1991 explicitly found divisions and incomplete control across bureaucratic sectors [Lane and Ross, 1995]. Thus, the very case sometimes imagined as the clearest monolith presents evidence against the assumption of total top-down unity.

A strong archival test would trace one strategic industrial sector across appointments, planned targets, ministerial bargaining, press accounts, coercive interventions, worker complaints, and reform efforts. Such evidence could identify which orders were actually implemented, where officials bargained or deviated, and whether grievances reached authorities able to remedy them. If a nominal central directive was routinely reshaped by local managers, the researcher would need to model a distributed bargaining network rather than a command chain.

This case additionally shows why ideology alone explains little. An anti-capitalist public doctrine does not guarantee the absence of elite privilege; equally, the absence of private capital markets does not prove that all public provision is exploitative. The mechanism to test is a particular arrangement of appointments, access, monitoring, and decision rights. It remains possible for publicly owned infrastructure to confer significant ordinary benefits even where other freedoms are constrained.

8.3 Post-socialist transition: exchange between private wealth and public authority

Some post-socialist transition economies provide an especially relevant illustration because ownership rights, regulation, and political institutions were renegotiated together. Hellman, Jones, and

Kaufmann's concept of state capture emerged from this context: in certain settings, influential firms sought to shape laws and regulations themselves rather than only obtain favors under existing rules [Hellman et al., 2000]. The relevant mechanism is neither uniquely capitalist nor a simple legacy of communism. It arises at a junction where concentrated private resources, public authority, and weakly institutionalized checks can reinforce one another.

Under the HBS vocabulary, the transition case predicts unusually observable cross-domain links: privatization decisions may alter wealth concentration, which may then affect rule-making capacity, which may protect the resulting ownership structure. But competing privatization strategies, political movements, independent journalists, courts, and international arrangements also shape trajectories. A careful design would compare similar sectors exposed to different regulatory processes, record reform chronology, and rule out preexisting structural differences.

The strongest evidence would connect a discrete change in ownership or appointments to subsequent legal or regulatory advantages, with supporting process documentation and a plausible counterfactual. Merely observing that formerly public assets became privately held and some owners became wealthy would not establish wrongful capture. Conversely, a documented transfer of rule-making discretion to connected beneficiaries, followed by sustained barriers to competition, would constitute stronger evidence of a reinforcing network.

8.4 Cross-case result: similarity at the functional level, difference in pathways

These illustrations imply no ranking of entire countries. They identify three possible pathways: wealth-to-rules, appointments-to-resources, and reciprocal capture during institutional transition. The same high-level functions appear in all three, but the relevant actors, protections, social benefits, and causal edges differ. That variation supports the modest claim of functional comparability while warning against the much stronger proposition that all political systems are equally coercive or are controlled by one stable group of masters.

9 Operationalizing the hierarchy: measurement before accusation

9.1 Units of observation and scope

The theory can be tested at three linked levels: individual policy decisions, institutional sectors, and country-years. Policy decisions are most defensible for identifying mechanisms because they permit a concrete timeline, identifiable actors, and a counterfactual. Sector studies reveal enduring appointment and funding networks. Country-year data enable broad comparison but impose substantial aggregation and measurement problems. We propose beginning with policy events and then using sector and country measures to examine generalizability.

Let c index country, s sector, p policy decision, and t year. The ideal dataset would include an edge table of actor pairs, a policy-events table, a regulatory and judicial review table, and contextual data on public preferences, economic conditions, and political institutions. Each recorded edge must specify evidence: an appointment instrument, disclosure, funding record, contractual obligation, organizational rule, documented instruction, or verified decision. Assumed personal sympathy or ideological similarity should not count as proof of a command relationship.

9.2 Proposed constructs and indicators

Construct	Operational indicator	Caveat and rival interpretation
Resource concentration	Ownership, controlled budget share, procurement awards, credit allocation	Scale can reflect efficiency or legitimate public infrastructure
Rule capture	Preferential exemptions, connected appointments, unusually asymmetric access	Policy preferences and technical merit may explain outcomes
Epistemic dependence	Funding share, sponsor influence on governance, restricted data access	Shared methods or valid scientific consensus can explain agreement
Coercive discretion	Politically selective sanctions, impunity, absent judicial remedy	Lawful enforcement may respond to actual misconduct
Worker dependency	Switching costs, bargaining coverage, job concentration, benefit portability	High employment concentration alone is not proof of compulsion
Accountability	Appeal rights, transparency, electoral replacement, independent audit	Formal rules may exist without being effective in practice
Cross-domain integration	Repeated overlapping appointments, budget authority, documented coordination	Expertise and legal coordination may be legitimate

Each indicator requires publicly stated coding rules. `Independent'' cannot mean`agrees with the researcher,'' and `captured'' cannot mean`produced an unpopular result.'' The criterion must be institutional: ability to publish contrary findings, replace leaders, demand documents, appeal decisions, and expose influence without retaliation. Coding should separate formal guarantees from observed functioning.

For governance context, the V-Dem dataset includes disaggregated measures of electoral and liberal democratic practices and institutional constraints; the 2026 version is a current candidate for preregistered comparisons [V-Dem Institute, 2026]. The World Bank's Worldwide Governance Indicators (WGI) provide estimates of voice and accountability, government effectiveness, regulatory quality, rule of law, control of corruption, and political stability [World Bank, 2026]. Both are imperfect proxies, not a direct HBS measure. Expert ratings may reflect uncertainty and disagreement; aggregate governance scores can hide sector-specific abuse; country comparisons should report measurement intervals where available.

One approach is a latent-variable model with H^*_{ct} representing unaccountable cross-domain concentration. Observed measures satisfy

$$Y_{jct} = \alpha_j + \lambda_j H^*_{ct} + \gamma_j' X_{ct} + u_{jct},$$

where Y_{jct} is indicator j, X_{ct} is a vector of measurement-relevant controls, and λ_j is an estimated loading. Measurement invariance must be examined across political systems and periods. A factor derived from expert judgments about election fairness may not measure the same construct in a regime without contested elections as in a democracy with plural institutions. The absence of invariance would argue for separate regime-specific models rather than a deceptively precise global score.

9.3 Hypotheses that could fail

H1: capture and closure. Within otherwise comparable policy sectors, greater concentration of discretionary benefits among connected actors will be associated with weaker effective opportunities for challenge, conditional on sector size and observable risk. The association should weaken after independent adjudication or transparent competitive entry becomes effective. An insignificant or opposite pattern after credible measurement would count against the proposed link.

H2: integration and durability. Organizations with repeated cross-domain control over appointments, funding, and sanctions will be more able to preserve preferential rules after adverse public disclosures than similarly resource-rich organizations lacking such integration. The dependent variable is measured persistence of specified preferential rules, not an analyst's subjective description of a regime.

H3: party-state pathway. In a one-party command sector, appointment chains should explain resource allocation and organizational survival more strongly than privately held capital shares, whereas in some market sectors concentrated ownership should explain more of observed policy access. This is a conditional proposition and might fail where enterprise autonomy, foreign investment, or informal patronage changes the effective channel.

H4: epistemic checks. Increasing independently governed access to administrative and scientific data should predict a greater rate of documented error discovery or successful policy correction, particularly in high-conflict sectors. A higher short-term rate of discovered problems can therefore indicate *stronger* accountability rather than worsening underlying behavior.

H5: worker voice. Where workers possess effective collective bargaining, legal protections, occupational mobility, and political representation, concentration in other domains should translate less readily into sustained material dependency. This prediction requires distinguishing nominal rights from practical accessibility and distinguishing individual exit from collective action.

H6: public goods as a rival outcome. Institutional concentration with high-quality external review may be associated with competent public service delivery and relatively low arbitrary sanctioning. If so, such cases weaken the claim that administrative centralization is inherently oppressive even if they display the visible five functions.

9.4 Identification and research design

Observational evidence faces endogeneity. Wealth may influence policy, but favorable policy can also create wealth. Public attitudes may shape media agendas, while media may shape public attitudes. Coercion may suppress protests, or protests may elicit lawful security deployment. Cross-sectional correlations among concentration, corruption, and perceived legitimacy will not resolve these directions.

A mixed-method design can improve identification. First, preregister a narrow policy universe and define outcomes independently of ideological expectations. Second, construct matched comparisons among sectors or jurisdictions with similar economic stakes but different transparency rules, appointment practices, or judicial review. Third, exploit plausibly external changes, such as the implementation of a disclosure reform or a staggered procedural requirement, while checking pre-trends and anticipating spillovers. Fourth, supplement statistical estimates with detailed process tracing. Fifth, compare cases that support and contradict the hypothesis, avoiding selection solely on notorious scandals.

An illustrative event-study specification is

$$Y_{cst} = \mu_{cs} + \tau_t + \sum_{k \neq -1} \beta_k D^{(k)}_{cs,t} + \theta' X_{cst} + \epsilon_{cst},$$

where Y could be an independently coded degree of preferential procurement or successful appeals, $D^{(k)}$ indicates time relative to an oversight reform, μ_{cs} is a sector-jurisdiction fixed effect, and τ_t a common time effect. Coefficients β_k are interpretable as causal only under substantive assumptions about the reform's selection, parallel trends, anticipation, and interference. Changes in reporting requirements may increase detected wrongdoing without increasing actual wrongdoing, so observed events should be triangulated with external audits.

A complementary network design would estimate whether cross-domain ties predict outcomes beyond resources alone. For example, compare organizations with similar spending or market shares but different numbers of legally verified board, committee, agency, or contracting connections. Control for size, industry, geographic scope, public mandates, and prior performance. Because many connections are lawful, network centrality is not an ethical verdict; associations must be traced to outcomes and checked against independent explanations.

9.5 What would falsify a strong version of the thesis?

Four findings would meaningfully undermine a generalized domination claim. First, disaggregated evidence might show that major policy domains are governed by unrelated actors whose interests frequently conflict. Second, accountability channels might repeatedly reverse advantages despite sustained concentrated advocacy. Third, worker vulnerability might be lower in settings with more public provision, contradicting the assumption that every expansion of institutional reach reduces freedom. Fourth, political transitions might produce durable shifts in resource allocation and legal authority, showing that the supposed hierarchy is more contestable than its framing predicts.

A theory must also specify what counts as *not* an HBS pattern. We propose that a strong classification require: documented unaccountable concentration in at least two distinct functions; demonstrated cross-domain influence; persistent restriction of effective contestation; and a materially consequential policy or sanctioning pattern linked to the concentrated coalition. These conditions are intentionally demanding. Without them, "Beast System'' remains a moral metaphor and should not be presented as an empirical finding.

10 Alternative explanations, scope conditions, and objections

10.1 The pluralist objection: there is no single apex

The clearest objection to the HBS metaphor is that complex polities seldom possess a unified center of command. Firms compete for revenue; politicians pursue reelection while officials protect agency autonomy; judges can restrain government; journalists seek stories inconvenient to advertisers; academics dispute accepted interpretations; and security organizations do not always share the priorities of political leadership. Dahl's pluralism was developed precisely against overly simple portraits of power concentrated in one social class [Dahl, 1961]. The original ladder would become analytically misleading if these conflicts were treated as theatrical performances hiding a guaranteed consensus.

The response is to distinguish **network hierarchy** from **single-actor monopoly**. A network can sustain durable advantage for a set of actors through reciprocal privileges even if members disagree on many issues. But this response imposes an evidentiary burden: specify the coalition, the coordination mechanism, the decision domain, and the duration. If those cannot be documented, the model should

record fragmented power rather than posit an invisible agreement. Strong organizations do not by themselves imply a strong coalition.

The model should also recognize sector-specific winners and losers. Military suppliers and public-health agencies may have divergent priorities; manufacturing employers and technology firms may disagree about immigration; university researchers may oppose pharmaceutical pricing decisions; labor organizations may ally with one administration and contest another. A national HBS score aggregating all these domains risks the ecological fallacy of attributing one behavior to every institution or member of a category.

10.2 The functionalist objection: concentration may be necessary

Large-scale public goods require coordination, standardized procedures, and credible enforcement. Disaster response may need unified command; financial supervision may require specialized expertise; infectious-disease surveillance may depend on standardized reporting; courts require recognized authority; and advanced infrastructure often requires long planning horizons. Mann's account of infrastructural state power makes this distinction central [Mann, 1984]. Treating every increase in capacity as domination would make the framework incapable of distinguishing competent governance from arbitrary rule.

A narrower conception asks whether discretionary decisions remain subject to rights, review, transparency, and revision. A centralized emergency response with time-limited powers and independent oversight differs from an indefinite order immune from challenge. A scientific regulator publishing methods and conflicts differs from an authority suppressing credible evidence. A state that can enforce ordinary contracts under due process differs from a state that selectively punishes political rivals. The distinction rests on institutional design and practice, not the scale of the organization alone.

Likewise, stable public trust cannot automatically be coded as indoctrination. People may trust institutions because those institutions deliver accurate information and reliable services. Low trust is not automatically a measure of democratic freedom; distrust can arise from misinformation, perceived injustice, poor performance, or successful exposure of abuse. Legitimacy must be studied independently using performance, accountability, and freedom of judgment as competing explanations.

10.3 The Marxian objection: material class relation is underdeveloped

The original hierarchy places resource holders above legal authorities and workers below enforcers. A Marxian critique would insist that property and production relations structure the categories themselves and that modern labor's position cannot be understood as mere obedience to law. This objection is important because the HBS vocabulary otherwise risks reifying occupational groups without explaining why particular distributions of ownership and bargaining power persist. Comparative political economy requires analysis of wages, capital accumulation, labor markets, bargaining institutions, and the distribution of surplus in addition to networks of officeholders.

The revised model treats the reproduction function as active rather than passive and permits changes in collective bargaining, ownership, and welfare institutions to transform other functions. It also treats state-socialist systems as materially distinct from privately owned capitalism rather than merely changing the names on a diagram. But the framework does not substitute for a complete theory of value, class formation, or capitalist accumulation. It is an institutional mid-range theory with limited ambition: identifying when power crosses functional boundaries without meaningful accountability.

10.4 The conservative and liberal objection: social order requires authority

Another objection holds that a strong critique of hierarchy may delegitimize law, expertise, and professional responsibility while ignoring the harms that arise when institutions are too weak to protect life and liberty. This is especially relevant to healthcare and public security. Without credible courts, legal property protections can collapse; without independent medical institutions, the public may face harmful treatments or uncontrolled disease; without reliable police oversight and capability, private coercion can flourish. The failure mode is not simply "too much state' ' but the wrong mix of power, responsibility, and limits.

The paper accordingly declines to endorse generalized institutional distrust. It proposes more demanding tests of authority. Genuine expertise should withstand scientific scrutiny; legitimate law should be challengeable through due process; legitimate coercion should remain proportionate and reviewable; and public finances should be traceable to authorized purposes. Institutions that meet these standards may exercise substantial power without fitting an HBS conception of unaccountable domination.

10.5 The methodological objection: a metaphor can explain everything and nothing

A broad theory becomes unfalsifiable if every result supports it. If media criticism of elites is labeled a controlled release, if failed legislation is called secret influence, if a court defeat is treated as a deceptive display, and if mass opposition is presumed manipulated, no observation could ever challenge the model. This is the structure of a self-sealing explanation rather than a research program. The paper explicitly rejects such immunity to counterevidence.

To retain scientific meaning, researchers must register negative cases, define the minimum evidence for coordination, and distinguish uncertain from supported links. Prediction intervals, rival hypotheses, source provenance, blinded coding where possible, and independent replication should become standard. In particular, when no verifiable bridge exists from a resource holder to a regulatory outcome, the result should be coded as unconfirmed, not inferred from the analyst's moral conviction.

10.6 The ethical objection: professional categories are not moral identities

People within the five functions have diverse interests and often work to protect those with less power. Nurses, judges, teachers, lawyers, civil servants, public defenders, police officers, journalists, scientists, business owners, and soldiers cannot be reduced to a single collective intention. Institutional critiques must identify actual decision structures and documented conduct. Blanket demonization of whole occupations distorts the research question and can encourage distrust of life-saving services or lawful protection.

The theological metaphor intensifies this obligation. Criticism of institutional arrangements is legitimate, but labeling people literal agents of supernatural evil is not an empirical explanation. The terms *master*, *slave*, and *beast* can carry rhetorical force; the working definitions used for testing must remain neutral enough to permit disagreement, revision, and disconfirmation. When producing results, the researcher should describe acts and mechanisms before applying charged symbols.

11 Accountability and institutional redesign

The framework is not complete unless it identifies where interventions might interrupt the proposed feedback loops. The most general principle is **separation of effective control accompanied by**

real opportunities for contestation. Formal organizational charts are not enough: oversight bodies need independence in appointment, resources, access to evidence, decision authority, and protection against retaliation. Nor is decentralization automatically beneficial; fragmentation can merely distribute unaccountable local fiefdoms. The aim is verifiable accountability, not maximal fragmentation for its own sake.

11.1 Resource and procurement transparency

Transparent public procurement, beneficial-ownership disclosure, conflict-of-interest rules, public registers of lobbying contacts, and audit trails can make resource-to-rule links more visible. OECD research on lobbying emphasizes both the legitimate informational role of advocacy and the need for transparency and integrity protections [Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, 2021]. The appropriate reform is not to silence organized interests but to allow citizens, journalists, firms, and civil-society groups to scrutinize unequal access and detect hidden privileges. Researchers should measure effects on costs, entry, competition, and corruption rather than assume that every transparency initiative works.

11.2 Legal remedies and institutional independence

Independent courts, rights to counsel, meaningful administrative appeal, public reasoning for decisions, legislative review, and protection for whistleblowers reduce the cost of contesting official error. Such safeguards are valuable across economic ideologies. Their effectiveness can be evaluated by case-processing times, appeal success, implementation of judgments, compliance by powerful agencies, and access for low-income parties. A constitutional guarantee without practical access may yield an inflated appearance of accountability.

11.3 Open knowledge and accountable expertise

Public release of research protocols, registries of conflicts of interest, reproducible analysis, freedom to publish negative findings, independent scientific review, and transparent standards-setting can protect epistemic institutions from capture. Public funding can be part of the solution when it diversifies research support and reduces reliance on a single commercial sponsor; it can be a problem when grant awards or publication are conditioned on conformity to political directives. The relevant variable is meaningful independence and verification, not whether the funding is public or private.

For healthcare and food regulation, a proportionate research agenda could examine disclosed sponsorships, post-market safety systems, independent clinical outcome data, access to second opinions, and clear routes for correcting agency errors. Broad accusations that drugs or food are designed as instruments of control should not substitute for such evidence. Good governance can demand scrutiny without discouraging treatment, nutrition, or professional care that demonstrably benefits the public.

11.4 Civilian control and accountable security

Civilian oversight, judicial authorization where required, transparent use-of-force standards, independent misconduct investigation, and protections for lawful assembly can reduce selective coercion. The goal is to ensure enforcement remains accountable to law rather than to a privileged coalition. Successful reform may increase recorded complaints or published incidents because transparency improves; evaluations must distinguish reporting changes from changes in underlying behavior. In the HBS model, effective scrutiny transforms the enforcement layer from an automatic transmitter of elite orders into a potentially independent guardian of rights.

11.5 Labor mobility, collective voice, and material security

Worker autonomy can grow through access to education, portable benefits, mobility, collective bargaining, fair legal procedures, market entry, and alternative sources of income. None alone is a universal remedy. A legal right to quit offers little practical independence if all local employers coordinate against workers; conversely, a public insurance program can reduce vulnerability without requiring a worker's permanent loyalty to one employer. Hirschman's *exit* and *voice* provide a useful language for these complementary protections [Hirschman, 1970].

The framework therefore does not imply that reduced taxation always increases freedom, nor that higher public expenditure always increases it. A program's institutional effects depend on who finances it, who receives the benefits, whether access is conditional on political conformity, whether administrators can be challenged, and whether its design expands citizens' real choices. This broader view is essential for comparisons between social-democratic, market-capitalist, and state-socialist orders.

12 Discussion: how to interpret the "Beast System'' responsibly

The model clarifies why the intuition can survive changes of economic ideology. Every large political economy needs rules, material inputs, knowledge, and credible mechanisms for carrying out decisions. Organizational specialization generates principal-agent problems and asymmetries of information, and concentrated stakes give some groups powerful incentives to organize. Under weak checks, these features can produce durable privileges and dependencies. But the steps from specialization to concentration, from concentration to capture, and from capture to domination are **empirical hypotheses**, not identities.

The distinction between **resources as master** and **political command as master** also matters theoretically. Where economic actors possess independent wealth and political competition persists, capture may occur through targeted policy pressure. Where a governing party controls strategic appointments and budgets, economic favors may be distributed internally as instruments of coalition management. Hybrid systems allow two-way conversion of wealth and office. These are different equilibria and should generate different observable pathways even when citizens experience similar constraints on particular decisions.

The proposed vocabulary may be especially useful for studying institutional cross-dependencies that conventional single-sector analysis misses. A funding decision can determine which evidence is produced; evidence can justify a rule; the rule can authorize sanctions; sanctions can alter workers' mobility; and changes in mobility can affect economic rents. To establish such a chain, however, analysts must identify and verify each link. A suggestive five-arrow picture is an explanatory invitation, not a causal proof.

The biblical term adds a morally serious question about the boundary between public authority and demanded allegiance. It can call attention to coercive exclusions from economic life and to the moral risks of presenting human institutions as infallible. Its usefulness depends on keeping the metaphor distinct from revelation-based empirical claims. A theological diagnosis of idolatrous political power may be internally meaningful within a religious tradition; a public research finding must still rest on independently accessible evidence.

Finally, the model directs attention toward public agency rather than helplessness. Citizens can investigate spending, practice professional ethics, participate in lawful associations, litigate, vote where elections are available, organize workers, create alternative providers, and demand evidence. A paper that simply places everyone beneath a pyramid risks reproducing the fatalism it seeks to criticize.

An adequate account must explain not only how domination might persist but also how institutions become accountable and why many people achieve genuine changes in the rules that govern them.

13 Conclusion

The Hierarchy of the Beast System can be formulated as a comparative theory of **unaccountable cross-domain concentration**, not as proof of a single clandestine government of society. Five functions—resource command, political-legal authority, knowledge mediation, enforcement, and social reproduction—recur in capitalist, state-socialist, and mixed orders. Their institutional occupants, causal directions, public benefits, and mechanisms of challenge are not constant. A simple vertical ladder is therefore an opening metaphor; the more defensible representation is a multiplex network with reversible pathways and potentially independent counterweights.

The paper's principal theoretical claim is conditional: where power is concentrated in multiple domains, coordination among those domains is documented, meaningful contestation is restricted, and privileged outcomes persist, the risk of domination increases. This claim draws on established research on elites, regulation, institutional economics, authoritarian stability, and accountability, but the integrated HBS construct is proposed here rather than empirically validated. Its propositions are falsifiable only when researchers state their coding thresholds, identify specific actors, include contrary cases, and assess rival explanations.

The Revelation imagery supplies an interpretive warning against the sacralization of human authority and the conditioning of economic participation on unchallengeable allegiance. It is not a historical proof that every wealthy person, lawyer, academic, physician, official, police officer, or worker belongs to one coordinated system. Political inquiry improves when strong moral questions are paired with disciplined causal evidence. The resulting research program seeks to distinguish necessary institutions from captured institutions, and concentrated capacity from arbitrary domination, across ideological boundaries.

14 Research limitations and disclosure

This manuscript is a conceptual synthesis based on publicly described literature and a proposed methodology. It has **not** implemented the coding scheme, estimated the model, collected a cross-national panel, produced new statistical findings, or established the numerical values of any proposed index. The case discussions are illustrative, not definitive assessments of contemporary countries. Concepts drawn from Christian scripture are identified as theological interpretation. Readers should not infer a particular individual's culpability from institutional membership or a particular product's safety from the discussion of regulatory incentives.

The bibliography combines canonical scholarly works and institutional data sources. Dates of publication and bibliographic metadata were checked selectively against publisher or institutional descriptions. The analysis contains ordinary scholarly uncertainty, including uncertainty about causal identification, measurement equivalence, national generalization, and the application of a theological metaphor to secular governance. No external funding, empirical data, or institutional endorsement is claimed.

15 Appendix A: proposed minimum data dictionary

Field	Definition	Suggested encoding
`country_period`	Bounded polity and years under study	ISO country code and inclusive years
`sector_policy`	Narrow policy or procurement domain	Controlled category and event ID
`actor_id`	Identified organization or legal decision maker	Stable identifier with provenance
`functional_roles`	Membership in R, L, K, E, W	Multi-label role vector
`link_type`	Resource, law, knowledge, sanction, reproduction	Enumerated mechanism
`link_evidence`	Verified source proving relationship	Archived document, record, or interview
`public_mandate`	Lawful purpose of organization	Mandate and governing instrument
`privileged_access`	Departure from ordinary access rules	Binary plus written justification
`decision_outcome`	Named policy, award, sanction, or review	Dated documentary outcome
`independent_review`	Whether the decision can be effectively challenged	Four-point scale with documentation
`material_effect`	Distributional and public benefit evidence	Effect estimate and uncertainty
`counterevidence`	Evidence against alleged coordinated control	Documented alternative explanation
`coder_confidence`	Quality and completeness of evidence	High, medium, low, indeterminate

A source record should retain original publication date, publisher or custodian, archival URL, accessed date, and the reason it bears on the inferred link. A coded accusation of capture should require agreement by independent reviewers using written rules and access to the same source documents. Disagreements should be preserved, not silently averaged away. Allegations of private misconduct should be handled through legal and ethical research procedures rather than public naming based on unverified inference.

16 Appendix B: illustrative preregistration protocol

Research question. Do documented resource-to-rule and appointment-to-resource connections increase the persistence of preferential institutional decisions, especially where appeals and disclosure are weak? Compare the directions and magnitudes of these pathways in matched democratic-market, party-state, and mixed-sector settings.

Population. All policy changes and procurement decisions within preregistered sectors and time periods, not only decisions that resulted in scandal coverage. The unit of analysis is the policy event; actors and organizations form a linked network. Record inclusion and exclusion decisions, including unavailable documents and policies with no discernible powerful beneficiary.

Primary outcomes. (i) Persistence of rules that confer exclusive privileges without a documented generalizable public-interest rationale; (ii) documented success of independent challenge; (iii) measured

distribution of benefits; and (iv) degree of public access to information. Privilege must be coded separately from illegality, technical merit, and the mere receipt of a government contract.

Exposures. Network integration among decision-relevant actors; concentration of control over resources; political appointment interlocks; documented access to rule-making; and the independence of review processes. Use measures fixed in advance rather than a single scale constructed after seeing results.

Controls. Baseline market structure, sector risk, public preferences where measurable, local income, international shocks, firm size, program complexity, and statutory mandate. Control for pre-treatment variables, avoiding indiscriminate adjustment for mediators caused by the exposure of interest.

Inference. Report raw contrasts, preregistered regression estimates, uncertainty intervals, sensitivity to hidden confounding, parallel-trend checks where applicable, and negative-control outcomes. Avoid causal language where identification assumptions are doubtful. If the sample cannot distinguish coalition influence from merit or ordinary political representation, report that limitation rather than produce a generalized institutional verdict.

Adversarial validation. A separate research group should try to falsify selected inferred links, search systematically for effective appeals or independent reporting, and identify cases in which concentrated public authority demonstrably expanded ordinary citizens' freedom. Publish coding instructions, the list of exclusions, summary provenance, and a correction mechanism before drawing broad comparative claims.

17 Appendix C: decision rules for interpretation

The proposed interpretation of a potential HBS pattern proceeds through five questions. First, are the organizations and decisions identifiable, or has the analysis substituted a vague collective category such as "elites''? Second, is there a documented power relationship, or only similarity of viewpoints? Third, did that relationship plausibly cause a decision or an enduring privilege? Fourth, were correction and contestation genuinely unavailable? Fifth, are there important public benefits or rival explanations that account for the observed arrangement? A single failed question prevents a confident conclusion of integrated capture.

These decision rules help prevent three recurrent reasoning errors: **composition**, in which misconduct by one official is attributed to an entire profession; **post hoc causation**, in which the temporal proximity of a donation and a regulation becomes proof of influence; and **unfalsifiable coordination**, in which all disagreement is reinterpreted as secretly controlled opposition. Each error can create the appearance of a total hierarchy even where evidence supports only localized conflicts of interest.

A practical standard is to maintain three labels: *established institutional relationship*, *plausible but unconfirmed mechanism*, and *normative or theological interpretation*. For example, a documented company-agency meeting may be established, influence over a subsequent rule may be unconfirmed, and the description of the arrangement as a "beast-like'' claim on allegiance remains theological rhetoric. Clear labeling makes it possible for readers with different political and religious commitments to evaluate the evidence on the same terms.

18 Appendix D: selected primary-source research inventory

For U.S. studies, potentially relevant source categories include lobbying disclosures, federal and state procurement records, administrative rulemaking dockets, judicial opinions, inspector-general audits, financial disclosures, and published scientific conflict-of-interest statements. For historical

state-socialist studies, relevant materials may include party appointment lists, ministerial archives, enterprise plans, worker petitions, official press records, and contemporaneous independent testimony, subject to availability and provenance review. For cross-national studies, V-Dem versioned downloads, WGI methodological documentation, and separately sourced political and economic series can provide context but should not be mistaken for direct proof of local capture [V-Dem Institute, 2026, World Bank, 2026].

The inventory is a blueprint rather than an assertion that these records have been gathered in this manuscript. Researchers should disclose missing archives, censorship or selection of surviving records, inconsistent reporting regimes, and the possibility that public datasets systematically undercount informal influence. Reliability depends on triangulation across sources with different incentives to misreport.

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